

"A ship's turnaround time used to be 96 hours. It had to wait for the green signal from port authorities. Now, it is 24 hours"

"Under the Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047, India aims to be one of the top five shipbuilding nations of the world"

"The Northeast has got Rs 7.9 lakh crore from the Centre since 2014. For the first time, the people there feel connected to Delhi"

SARBANANDA SONOWAL
Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways



WHEN A COUNTRY COMMITS 4 PER CENT OF ITS ANNUAL BUDGET, nearly Rs 17 lakh crore, to infrastructure alone, the conversation can never be small. Or boring. The third edition of the INDIA TODAY Infrastructure Conclave on February 25 was witness to a well-rounded blueprint for a country aiming to meet global standards in transportation, manufacturing and tech infrastructure. Leading politicians, bureaucrats, academics and industry leaders gathered to deliberate on what has been achieved, remains to be done and the challenges ahead.

All eyes were on Nitin Gadkari, Union minister of road transport and highways, who declared that the country's highways would rival America's in just two years, and a beaming Sarbananda Sonowal, Union minister of ports, shipping and waterways, who boasted about India's turnaround time for ships at ports now being less than even that of the US or Canada.

Money is not seen as a barrier by Manoj Kumar Dubey, chairman and managing director of Indian Railways Finance Corporation, when it comes to building the seven high-speed rail corridors announced in this year's budget. Expansion plans for the capital's subway lines were elaborated by Vikas Kumar, chairman and managing director of Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, while Prof. Geetam Tiwari of IIT Delhi pointed out that last-mile connectivity remains a persistent challenge.

The aviation industry saw ambitious claims by Vinay Dube, founder-CEO of Akasa Air, who spoke of making his mark with the new airline in a sector dominated by two giants, IndiGo and Air India. Videh Kumar Jaipuriar, CEO of Delhi International Airport Ltd, said that Delhi is on par to be a global aviation hub, though Kapil Kaul, CEO of the think tank CAPA India, reminded everyone that the task will take more than meets the eye.

In the tech space, Abhishek Singh, CEO of India's AI Mission, exuded confidence, fresh out of the AI summit as he was, and said that India plans to overtake the US and China in developing the nascent technology "in due course".

If there was one thing that the Conclave proved, it was that India's infrastructure ambitions are global, with the country meaning to not just catch up, but lead. ■

—Avishek G. Dastidar

Photographs by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR, HARDIK CHHABRA, ATUL KUMAR YADAV